BY ORDER OF THE COMMANDER
ROBINS AIR FORCE BASE

ROBINS AIR FORCE BASE
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Aerospace Medicine

MOLD PREVENTION PROGRAM

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This publication implements DAFI48-145, Occupational and Environmental Health and the Bioenvironmental Engineering Technical guide to Indoor Air Quality Surveys. It applies to all Air Force military, civilian, and contracted personnel working at or on Robins Air Force Base (RAFB) or supported sites. This instruction is directive in nature. This publication may be supplemented at any level, but all direct supplements must be routed to the high headquarters OPR of this publication for coordination prior to certification and approval. Requests for waivers must come through the chain of command from the commander of the office seeking relief from compliance. Waiver requests must be submitted to the OPR; waiver authority has not been delegated. The waiver approval authority for all compliance items within this publication are at Wing Level (Tier T-3). Refer recommended changes and questions about this publication to the Office of Primary Responsibility (OPR) using AF Form 847, *Recommendation for Change of Publication*. Route AF Form 847 from the field through the chain of command of the appropriate functional. Ensure that all records created as a result of processes prescribed in this publication are maintained in accordance with Air Force Instruction (AFI33-322), *Records Management and Information Governance Program*, and disposed of in accordance with Air Force Records Information Management System (AFRIMS) Records Disposition Schedule (RDS) located at **https://www.my.af.mil/afrims/afrims/afrims/rims.cfm.** See **Attachment 1** for a glossary of references and supporting information.

Chapter 1

OVERVIEW

1.1. This publication establishes responsibilities, policies, and procedures to inform members on mold and fungal mitigation. As well as the steps taken once a member has been medically affected by mold or fungus on base.

Chapter 2

ROLES AND RESPONSIBILITIES

2.1. The Installation Commander (78 ABW/CC) will:

2.1.1. Ensure members on base have access to clean work environments, lacking mold or fungal growth and water damage.

2.2. Base Civil Engineering (78 CEG):

2.2.1. Ensure proper maintenance of any leaks, breaks, etc. that could be producing a potential indoor air quality or mold issue in the workplace are addressed within a timely manner.

2.2.2. If an occupant relocation is necessary while maintenance is being completed, notify the Commander or Director of the affected unit.

2.2.3. Provide and review training on base mold procedures for all members on base.

2.3. Bioenvironmental Engineering (BE) will:

2.3.1. Upon request from the building Facility Manager or Civil Engineering, will conduct an inspection for mold and other indoor air quality concerns.

2.3.2. Advise members and Civil Engineering Squadron on water damage remediation efforts.

2.3.3. If there is a concern about worker health that has been validated by a physician, an indoor air quality assessment will be performed to determine the health of the ambient air.

2.4. Occupational Medicine Services (OMS) will:

2.4.1. Advise or treat members who may have been adversely affected by potential mold or fungal growth in the workplace.

2.5. Commanders or Directors of Units with Potential Mold Issues will:

2.5.1. Notify the affected members with health-related concerns as a result of the potential mold to see their Primary Care Manager (PCM) or civilian equivalent medical provider.

2.5.2. Notify the Unit Facility Manager of any potential concerns of mold or fungal growth and water damage.

2.6. Unit Facility Manager will:

2.6.1. Ensure proper functioning of the facility.

2.6.2. Notify of any potential mold or air quality concerns affecting worker health.

2.6.3. Obtain training from 78 CEG on mold response.

2.7. Members on Base will:

2.7.1. Notify their facility managers of any potential water leaks or mold concerns.

2.7.2. Seek medical attention if they believe they are having symptoms related to mold exposure.

Chapter 3

RESPONSES TO WATER DAMAGE AND MOLD CONCERNS

3.1. Overview. Molds are types of fungi that are found naturally in soil, food, or in any other wet porous materials or surfaces. Molds travel indoors through windows, doorways, and on clothing, shoes, and pets. Mold grows best in warm, humid environments with poor ventilation. They thrive primarily on organic surfaces including wood, paper, drywall, ceiling tiles, carpets, and upholstery. People are exposed to mold and other microbes nearly continuously and every day. Each person reacts to mold differently. In healthy people, there is little risk for serious illness caused by mold. Symptoms that may seem to occur from mold exposure, may actually be due to other causes such as building humidity, bacterial, or viral infections. People with allergies or asthma may notice that mold makes their symptoms worse. People with mold sensitivities can experience stuffy nose, coughing, wheezing, and red itchy eyes or skin. If someone's immune system does not work properly, they can develop more serious symptoms. These symptoms include fever, shortness of breath, and rarely, even an infection.

3.2. Bioenvironmental Engineering Flight.

3.2.1. BE can conduct Indoor Air Quality (IAQ) assessments, where BE Flight will compare temperature, humidity, and CO2 levels to the career recommended levels within the ambient air in a work environment.

3.2.2. BE will make recommendations to Civil Engineering Squadron and the Commander or Director of the affected unit on water damage remediation. This includes carpet change out, furniture removal, etc.

3.2.3. BE will conduct a walkthrough of a facility or building with a member of Occupational Medicine Services potential mold concerns at the recommendation of a Primary Care Manager (PCM) or a civilian equivalent medical provider. Mold is not deemed hazardous to the individual's health, unless stated by an appropriate medical provider. All mold will still be advised to be removed from the facility or building.

3.2.4. BE does not have the capability to sample for mold. Mold testing is expensive and is not recommended. There are thousands of mold species and no accepted national or international mold health standards. Therefore, health effects cannot be associated to a specific mold level. Additionally, indoor airborne mold levels are extremely variable and laboratory sampling results are highly uncertain. You cannot rely on mold sampling or culturing to determine an individual's health risk. Resources are better spent removing mold and controlling sources of moisture. Individuals who believe that they have a health concern related to mold present in the workplace should contact their PCM or provider equivalent. If the PCM/provider equivalent determines that the health concern is related to a specific species of mold, the PCM/provider equivalent will reach out to Occupational Medicine Squadron (OMS). OMS and BE will then determine if sampling for mold is necessary.

3.3. Mitigation Efforts.

3.3.1. The Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) recommends maintaining indoor relative humidity between 30-60% to reduce mold growth. Ensure high moisture areas such as bathrooms, kitchens, and laundry rooms vent outdoors. Beware of humidifiers and infusers as they can contribute to humidity. If water accumulates on your windows, wipe it off, especially around the edges.

3.3.2. Most mold related symptoms are treatable with over-the-counter allergy medicines. You should speak to a healthcare professional if you are experiencing persistent symptoms or have health concerns. Mold spores may remain in the environment after visible mold growth has been removed or cleaned; therefore, symptoms may continue shortly after.

3.3.3. If you find signs of mold, remove or repair excessive moisture sources like leaking pipes and clear standing water as soon as possible. Remove humidity with a dehumidifier, air conditioner, or ventilation. Visible mold should be cleaned. If mold keeps returning, notify your local base housing office or facility manager for assistance.

3.3.4. Absorptive material such as drywall and carpets that get wet should be dried within 48-hours and monitored for mold growth. Other materials (e.g., cloth, papers) should be laundered or discarded as appropriate. If the surface is hard and smooth, like a tile or baseboard, use soapy water or a non-ammonia cleaner with a stiff brush to scrub away any visible mold. Bleach and biocides are not recommended for routine mold cleanup and may be hazardous to occupants. It is impossible to completely eliminate all mold and mold spores in the indoor environment, but this will help reduce excessive mold growth.

Chapter 4

ADDITIONAL RESOURCES

4.1. Base Resources.

4.1.1. Robins AFB has several resources available for facility managers or members concerned about mold in the workplace. This information is available through both 78 CEG and BE and is accessible by request through the workplace facility manager. Please see **Attachment 2** for the standard response at Robins AFB for mold issues and **Attachment 3** for the customer trifold created by BE.

4.2. Outside Resources.

4.2.1. The Air Force and several outside agencies offer additional guidance on mold mitigation and clean up. Please see **Attachment 1** for more information.

4.3. Key Contacts.

4.3.1. BE (Duty Hours): 478-327-7555

4.3.2. BE (Off Duty Hours): 478-957-2990

4.3.3. OMS: 478-327-7597

LINDSAY C. DROZ, Colonel, USAF
Commander, 78th Air Base Wing

Attachment 1

GLOSSARY OF REFERENCES AND SUPPORTING INFORMATION

References

AFI 33-322, *Records Management and Information Management Systems,* 28 Jul 2021

DAFI 48-145, *Occupational and Environmental Health,* 22 Sep 2022

USAFSAM, *Bioenvironmental Engineering Technical Guidance for Indoor Air Quality Surveys*, July 2014

EPA*, Building Air Quality*, December 1991

AIHA, *The Facts About Mold*, 2020

OSHA, *Indoor Air Quality in Commercial and Institutional Building*, 2011

EPA, *Office Building Occupant's Guide to Indoor Air Quality*, October 1997

Abbreviations and Acronyms

AFI—Air Force Instruction

AFRIMS—Air Force Records Information Management System

BE—Bioenvironmental Engineering

EPA—Environmental Protection Agency

IAQ—Indoor Air Quality

IAW—in accordance with

OMS—Occupational Medicine Services

OPR—Office of Primary Responsibility

PCM—Primary Care Manager

RDS—Records Distribution Schedule

RAFB—Robins Air Force Base

Attachment 2

STANDARD RESPONSE TO MOLD ISSUES

Figure A2.1. Standard Response to Mold Issues.

